



BEFORE

At the start of the Civil War, only a few men on the Confederate side had military training. Recruits were volunteers, often led by amateur military enthusiasts.

FORMING AN ARMY

At first the Confederacy based its army on **state militias**, preexisting **volunteer companies**, and a rush of one-year volunteers at the **outbreak of war** (see [Raising Armies](#)). The army's dependence on **one-year enlistment** from spring 1861 held **the prospect of a crisis** when the volunteers' term of service expired. In December 1861, the Confederate Congress **offered inducements to tempt men into reenlisting**. They were offered a 60-day furlough (or break), a cash bounty, and the right to join a new regiment and to elect new officers.

INTRODUCTION OF CONSCRIPTION

Generals, however, feared that these measures would disrupt the war effort. On April 16, 1862, the Confederacy decided to **introduce conscription**, known as the "draft." **White males aged 18-35** were subject to **compulsory military service** and one-year service men had to stay for three years. In September, the **upper age limit was raised to 45**. Initially, planters with 20 or more slaves were exempt. In addition, the wealthy could pay someone to fight on their behalf. Many men **volunteered rather than be conscripted**: of around 200,000 enrolments in 1862, the majority were volunteers.

The majority of Confederate troops—more than 60 percent of the total—were farmers and farm laborers, a proportion that broadly reflected the social makeup of the Southern states. Some were just boys—normally serving as buglers or drummers—but most were between 18 and 29 years of age. In contrast to the Union forces, the Confederates were ethnically homogeneous, their ranks including relatively few recent immigrants and no Black Americans.

The majority of Confederate soldiers either came from a slave-holding household, a household that rented enslaved people, or from an area in which enslaved people were present. Almost all Confederate soldiers believed that the preservation of slavery was essential to their status and security and saw the war as a defense of their home and way of life. Southerners also tended to believe the myth that they were natural fighters compared to the decadent urban Yankees from the North, and cultivated a self-conscious sense of personal honor that impelled them into combat. This self-image also sustained their commitment to the war.

As the Confederate soldiers' initial enthusiasm waned, many came to feel that they were poor men fighting a rich man's war. The